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Mental Health Stigma: How It Effects People, Why It Needs to Be Reduced

A mental disorder is a significant disturbance in a person's cognition, emotional regulation, or behavior. There are many types of mental disorders. The broader term used for mental disorders is mental health conditions (Mental). There are many negative feelings associated with mental illnesses. A person who is known to have a mental illness might face a lot of discrimination. They might also find themselves at the receiving end of bullying and unfair treatment.

The World Health Organization, a specialized agency responsible for international public health, reports "In 2019, 1 in every 8 people, or 970 million people around the world were living with a mental disorder" (Mental). According to a study co-led by researcher from Harvard Medical School and the University of Queensland, "One out of every two people in the world will develop a mental health disorder in their lifetime. The findings are based on structured, face-to-face surveys of more than 150,000 adults across 29 countries of varying wealth from all of the regions of the world" (half).

Despite the increasing number of people with disorders, many of them do not get treated either because they do not have access to effective care or because of the stigma, discrimination associated with mental health (Mental).

According to psychological scientist, Patrick Corrigan,

Over 60 million Americans are thought to experience mental illness in a given year, and the impacts of mental illness are undoubtedly felt by millions more in the form of family members, friends, and coworkers. Despite the availability of effective evidence-based treatment, about 40% of individuals with serious mental illness do not receive care and many who begin an intervention fail to complete it (Corrigan).

Mental illness stigma is when someone is viewed in a negative light due to their mental health conditions i.e., when someone is labeled as a collection of symptoms rather than as a person (Mental Illness). There are types of mental illness stigma – public stigma, and self-stigma (Borenstein).

Self-stigma - negative attitudes including internalized shame, that an individual with mental illness has about one's own condition also has an effect on that person “A 2017 study involving more than 200 individuals with mental illness over a period of two years found that greater self-stigma was associated with poorer recovery from mental illness after one and two years” (Borenstein).

An article, reviewed by Jeffrey Borenstein who has a Doctor of Medicine, published by the American Psychiatric Association, the largest psychiatric association in the world, shows how public stigma (negative attitudes people have about mental illness affects them), “More than half of people with mental illness don't receive help for their disorders. Often, people avoid or delay seeking treatment due to concerns about being treated differently or fears of losing their jobs and livelihood. That's because stigma, prejudice and discrimination against people with mental illness is still very much a problem” (Borenstein).

The story of Sian, who experienced discrimination at her workplace due to her mental health conditions,

I was open from the start about my diagnoses and the reasonable adjustments I needed to enable me to perform to my best. The issues started out small; a snide comment here, a little dig there. Gradually, things escalated, always badged as being “for my own good”. Work was taken off me, I was left out of meetings, I was micro-managed and previously existing adjustments were suddenly deemed as unfair to others. If I wasn’t in the office, I had to send emails detailing where I had been, and what I had been working on. After four years, the stress finally made me crack and led to a number of suicide attempts over a short period. Unfortunately, this only spurred on the discrimination, with a concerted effort launched when I returned to work to drive me from the organization, with regular performance reviews and multiple meetings with HR (Sian’s).

I had a cousin who suffered from a mental disorder, his thinking was not developed fully, he couldn’t quite articulate his words fully and he was basically a child in an adult's body. I was afraid of him when I was a child, I used to hide behind my parents whenever we went to their place. He usually can identify people so, when we go to their place, he used to express his happiness by trying to hug them but as I was afraid, I used to avoid him or run from him. At that age, I never understood the implications of my actions but the way I acted might have caused him sadness. His parents treated him very well, they did not abandon him, but they did refuse to take him to the mental health doctor because they thought if word got out that their son was admitted to a hospital for his mental illness, he would be made fun of more than he already was. So, he did not get better, he remained the same. One day when he was out with his family (to a farm), he wandered a bit and did not return for quite some time, they went looking for him and found his body in a nearby lake. He died by drowning; he probably went into the water for fun as he did not know the dangers associated with it and he probably couldn’t shout for help too because he could not articulate his responses properly.

This might have been avoided if he was treated. The negative feelings associated with mental illness and taking treatment for it resulted in the death of him.

This is just one of the many stories that happen in reality. The fact here is, many think people with mental health problems are prone to cause problems, make mistakes or commit crimes. This might be either a conscious or subconscious thought, but it happens. Some try to understand while some bully/avoid them for it. Sometimes the people who avoid or make fun of people with mental disorders might be their own family members. They might neglect them, leave them on the streets, or abuse them because they think a child who is 'sick in their head' as they say it, is not someone they want.

Many people believe that someone with mental illness is more inclined to commit a crime but according to an article published by the American Psychological Association, the largest scientific and professional organization of psychologists in the United States, "In a study of crimes committed by people with serious mental disorders, only 7.5 percent were directly related to symptoms of mental illness" (Peterson). A lead researcher, Jillian Peterson, PhD says "When we hear about crimes committed by people with mental illness, they tend to be big headline-making crimes, so they get stuck in people's heads. The vast majority of people with mental illness are not violent, not criminal and not dangerous" (Peterson).

This type of public stigma of mental health illness just leads the people with them to think low of themselves, they might become insecure, and it might also lead to suicide. Public stigma instills self-stigma.

A study of stigma among adolescents taking psychiatric medication discovered through qualitative interviews that 90% of participants demonstrated at least one of three measured stigma themes: secrecy, shame, and limiting social interaction. Many of these adolescents endorsed

feeling some stigma from their friends or peers. Others expressed fear of being bullied by peers in school environments, consequently leading to secrecy, shame, and social withdrawal (Lippman).

This stigmatization from family and peers not only negatively affects an adolescent's psyche, but it might also lead them to define themselves by their illness, a phenomenon called self-labeling (Lippman). For example, if someone with autism or any other disorder is asked to describe their personality the first thought that comes to their mind might be 'I am autistic.'

Moses (2008) found that adolescents who self-label "refer to their illness as an organic part of themselves," merging their own identity with that of their psychiatric disorder. These findings suggest that individuals who cannot separate who they are from their diagnoses might experience poorer psychological well-being that likely seeps into their academic performance, as well as other dimensions of their daily lives (Lippman).

Some people use mental disorders as a reason for not taking a person seriously. For example, 'Oh, you are depressed so I don't believe a word you say' or 'You have anxiety, your notes are probably messy.' While people with mental disorders cannot do some things properly, it is not true that they just cannot do anything. Treating them as someone incapable or unworthy because of something they probably have no control over is unfair.

There are ways to reduce this. Some steps that can be taken at schools to reduce this stigma are,

Community awareness campaigns: through school newsletters, community information nights etc. Curriculum-based learning programs: that explicitly teach about mental health issues and develop students' mental health literacy. Developing a safe and supportive environment: for everyone, including those students, staff and community members whose lives are affected by a mental health difficulty. Modelling respect for people affected by mental health difficulties: you can do this by treating people with mental health difficulties as individuals, rather than being defined by their mental health, and correcting others if they make stereotypical or unsupportive remarks (Reducing Mental).

The same steps can be taken in other social settings like workplaces etc.

The National Alliance on Mental Illness (NAMI) has some great ideas on ways we all can break stigma around behavioural health challenges. Talk openly about mental health. Educate yourself and others – respond to misperceptions or negative comments by sharing facts and experiences. Be conscious of language. Encourage equality between physical and mental. Be honest about treatment – normalize mental health treatment, just like other health care treatment. Show compassion for those with mental illness. Choose empowerment over shame (Reducing).

It is not an easy process (reducing the stigma), but everything starts small. People should be understanding and not make fun of those with mental disorders. Giving support, encouraging them to take treatment, when necessary, and trying to understand their situation can mean a lot to them. If you are not willing to support, then at least try not to hate or judge them just based on a mental illness. Words are powerful, if possible, use them to be positive or to bring a change not to hate or insult.

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